Everyday Conversational AI and Psychological Well-Being: A Systematic Review of Self-Directed, Non-Clinical Use

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Abstract

Conversational AI is increasingly used for companionship and emotional support in everyday life. We systematically reviewed peer-reviewed studies of self-directed, non-clinical use. Seven studies met the inclusion criteria, with a combined total of 2,148 participants from four countries. Short-term emotional comfort and loneliness relief were commonly reported, while evidence for durable well-being was limited. Some studies reported risks of emotional dependence among vulnerable users.

1. Introduction

Conversational artificial intelligence is increasingly used in ordinary digital life for companionship, emotional expression and social interaction. Evidence from purpose-built therapeutic chatbots cannot automatically be generalised to voluntary, self-directed everyday use. Little is known about how everyday use relates to psychological and social well-being. This review aimed to synthesise the evidence on self-directed conversational AI use and well-being outcomes.

2. Method

We searched Scopus, Web of Science, PubMed and PsycINFO in January 2026 following PRISMA 2020 guidelines. The database searches identified 1,284 records. After 312 duplicates were removed, 972 records were screened by title and abstract. A total of 41 full-text articles were assessed for eligibility. Seven studies were included in the final synthesis. Study quality was appraised with the Mixed Methods Appraisal Tool, and findings were synthesised narratively.

3. Results

Users commonly reported short-term emotional comfort and loneliness relief after conversations with companion chatbots. Perceived social support was higher among regular users in two cross-sectional studies. Evidence on life satisfaction was mixed across studies. One longitudinal study found no significant change in depressive symptoms over three months. Two studies reported emotional dependence among users with high baseline loneliness.

Table 1 summarises the characteristics of the included studies.

Table 1. Characteristics of included studies

	Country	Design	N	Chatbot	Main outcome
	United States	Mixed-method	131	Replika	Loneliness, trust
	United Kingdom	Cross-sectional	612	Character.AI	Social support
	China	Longitudinal	245	Xiaoice	Depressive symptoms
	Nigeria	Qualitative	23	ChatGPT	Emotional comfort
	Brazil	Cross-sectional	804	Replika	Life satisfaction

4. Discussion

The selected evidence supports a distinction between proximal socioemotional experiences and distal or sustained well-being. Vulnerability profiles and longitudinal findings suggest that benefits may depend on usage patterns. These findings highlight the need for design safeguards for vulnerable users.

5. Limitations

The evidence base is limited by the predominance of cross-sectional and self-report designs. The review was restricted to English-language, peer-reviewed publications.

6. Conclusion

Self-directed conversational AI has heterogeneous well-being associations that vary by outcome timescale, relational function, usage pattern and user vulnerability. Short-term comfort should not be mistaken for lasting well-being.

References

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